

The Hiker's Mushroom Guide

Spot, Identify & Stay Safe on the Trail

By Paola Adventurer | Archery · Camping · Explore

How to Use This Guide

Hey! If you're reading this, you're probably the kind of person who notices things on the trail that most people walk right past. That weird orange shelf growing on a fallen oak. That white pom-pom hanging from a beech tree. That golden funnel poking out of the moss.

You've been curious. Now you'll know what you're looking at.

This guide covers 10 mushrooms every hiker should recognize — 7 edible species and 3 deadly toxic ones. For each one, you'll get:

- What it looks like (cap, gills/pores, stem, size)
- Where and when to find it
- Which regions it grows in
- What it could be confused with
- Whether it's safe or dangerous

How to search by area: Jump to the **Regional Quick-Reference** at the end of this guide. Find your region, see which of the 10 mushrooms grow there, and flip to those pages.

Want to print? Each mushroom takes up its own section. Print only the ones you need for your area, or print the full guide — your call.

IMPORTANT SAFETY NOTICE: This guide is for educational purposes and general identification awareness. Never eat a wild mushroom based solely on a written guide. When in doubt, leave it alone. If you suspect mushroom poisoning, call Poison Control (1-800-222-1222 in the US) or your local emergency number immediately. Always consult with an experienced forager or mycologist before consuming any wild mushroom.

Golden Rules Before You Start

Before we get into the mushrooms, burn these five rules into your brain:

1. **When in doubt, throw it out.** No meal is worth a hospital visit. If you're not 100% sure, walk away.
 2. **Never eat raw wild mushrooms.** Even the safe ones need to be cooked.
 3. **Start with one species at a time.** Don't try to learn all 10 at once. Pick one edible, learn it cold, then move to the next.
 4. **Spore prints don't lie.** When visual ID isn't enough, a spore print gives you a second confirmation. Place the cap gill-side down on a piece of paper (half white, half dark) for 4–8 hours. The color of the spore deposit narrows your ID fast.
 5. **Photograph everything.** Cap top, underside (gills/pores), stem, base, and the surrounding habitat. If you need help from a local foraging group later, these photos are gold.
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THE EDIBLE 7

1. Chanterelle

Cantharellus cibarius

Status: EDIBLE — Beginner-friendly

What it looks like

- **Cap:** Golden to egg-yolk yellow, 2–5 inches wide, wavy and funnel-shaped with irregular edges
- **Underside:** False gills — forked ridges that run down the stem, not true blade-like gills. This is the key ID feature
- **Stem:** Solid, same color as the cap, tapers toward the base
- **Flesh:** White to pale yellow when cut open
- **Smell:** Fruity, almost like apricots
- **Size:** 1–6 inches tall

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Forest floors near oaks, conifers, and hardwoods. Grows from the ground (never from wood)
- **Season:** Summer through early fall (June–October)
- **Grows:** Scattered or in small groups, rarely in dense clusters

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast | Midwest

Watch out for: Jack O'Lantern (TOXIC — #10 in this guide)

The Jack O'Lantern is the chanterelle's evil twin. Key differences: - Jack O'Lanterns have **true, sharp gills** (not forked ridges) - Jack O'Lanterns grow **in clusters on wood** (chanterelles grow alone from soil) - Jack O'Lanterns glow faintly **in the dark** (bioluminescent)

If you find one

Cook thoroughly in butter or oil. Never eat raw. Chanterelles are meaty, peppery, and slightly fruity — one of the best-tasting wild mushrooms in the world.

2. Morel

Morchella esculenta

Status: EDIBLE — Beginner-friendly

What it looks like

- **Cap:** Honeycomb-like surface with deep pits and ridges, tan to dark brown, cone-shaped
- **Inside:** Completely hollow from top to bottom when sliced in half — this is the #1 ID feature
- **Stem:** White to cream, also hollow, slightly granular texture
- **Size:** 2–6 inches tall

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Near dead or dying elms, ash, apple, and tulip poplar trees. Loves burned areas (post-wildfire spots are morel goldmines)
- **Season:** Spring (March–May), one of the first mushrooms of the year
- **Grows:** Alone or in scattered groups

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast | Midwest | Rocky Mountains

Watch out for: False Morel (*Gyromitra esculenta*)

The false morel can cause serious illness or death. Key differences: - False morels have **brain-like, wrinkled caps** (not a clean honeycomb pattern) - False morels are **NOT hollow** inside — they have cottony, chambered flesh - When in doubt, slice it in half. Hollow = true morel. Chambered = false morel. Walk away.

If you find one

Soak in salt water for 30 minutes to remove insects. Cook thoroughly — never eat raw. Morels are nutty, earthy, and considered a delicacy.

3. Chicken of the Woods

Laetiporus sulphureus

Status: EDIBLE — Beginner-friendly

What it looks like

- **Shape:** Large shelf/bracket fungus growing in overlapping layers on tree trunks or logs
- **Top:** Bright orange to salmon
- **Underside:** Bright sulfur-yellow with tiny pores (no gills)
- **Flesh:** Thick, white, firm when young — gets chalky and tough when old
- **Size:** Individual shelves 2–12 inches wide; entire cluster can be 2+ feet across

Where & when

- **Habitat:** On dead or living hardwoods, especially oaks. Also found on dead conifers (but avoid those — see note below)
- **Season:** Late spring through fall (May–November)
- **Grows:** In large shelving clusters on wood — never from the ground

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast | Midwest

Watch out for

- **Avoid specimens growing on conifers, eucalyptus, or yew trees** — they can cause GI distress even though the mushroom itself is the same species
- **Old specimens** turn pale, chalky, and crumbly — only eat young, vibrant ones

If you find one

Young chicken of the woods has a texture remarkably similar to actual chicken breast when cooked. Slice the tender outer edges (skip the tough base), sauté in oil with garlic, and season. A favorite for trail-to-table meals.

4. Hen of the Woods (Maitake)

Grifola frondosa

Status: EDIBLE — Beginner-friendly

What it looks like

- **Shape:** Large rosette of overlapping, fan-shaped caps growing from a single base — looks like a ruffled hen sitting at the base of a tree
- **Color:** Gray-brown on top, white underneath
- **Underside:** Tiny white pores (no gills)
- **Stem:** Short, branching, white, all connected at a central core
- **Size:** Can grow massive — 10 to 50+ pounds in a single cluster

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Base of living or dead hardwoods, especially oaks. Returns to the same spot year after year
- **Season:** Fall (September–November)
- **Grows:** In large clusters at the base of trees

Regions

Northeast | Southeast | Midwest

Watch out for: Black-Staining Polypore (*Meripilus sumstinei*)

Similar look, but: - **Stains black** when bruised or cut — hen of the woods does not - Not dangerous, but not as good eating

If you find one

Maitake is prized in Japanese cuisine. Tear into pieces, sauté until crispy on the edges. Rich, savory, umami-heavy flavor. Dries and freezes well for later use.

5. Lion's Mane

Hericium erinaceus

Status: EDIBLE — Virtually no dangerous look-alikes

What it looks like

- **Shape:** A single white globe covered in long, cascading, icicle-like spines — looks like a white pom-pom or a waterfall of tiny teeth
- **Color:** Pure white when young, yellowing with age
- **No cap, no stem, no gills** — completely unique shape
- **Size:** 4–12 inches across

Where & when

- **Habitat:** On dead or dying hardwoods, especially beech, oak, and maple. Grows high up on standing dead trees or on fallen logs
- **Season:** Late summer through fall (August–November)
- **Grows:** Single specimens on wood

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast | Midwest

Watch out for

Almost nothing. Lion's mane is one of the safest wild mushrooms to identify because nothing else looks quite like it. Other *Hericiium* species (bear's head, coral tooth) are all edible too.

If you find one

Slice into thick "steaks" and sear in butter until golden on both sides. The texture is like crab or lobster — no joke. Also valued for potential cognitive health benefits.

6. Oyster Mushroom

Pleurotus ostreatus

Status: EDIBLE — Beginner-friendly

What it looks like

- **Cap:** Fan or oyster-shell shaped, 2–8 inches wide, smooth
- **Color:** White, cream, gray, or tan (sometimes pale brown)
- **Gills:** White, running down a short stubby stem (or no stem at all)
- **Stem:** Short, off-center, attached to the side of the cap
- **Grows on:** Dead hardwood — logs, stumps, standing dead trees
- **Smell:** Mild, pleasant, slightly like anise
- **Size:** Individual caps 2–8 inches; clusters can cover a log

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Dead or dying hardwoods. Loves fallen logs in damp forests
- **Season:** Spring and fall primarily, but can fruit year-round in mild climates — even in winter
- **Grows:** In overlapping shelf-like clusters on wood

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast | Midwest | Rocky Mountains

Watch out for: Angel Wings (*Pleurocybella porrigens*)

- Angel wings are **pure white, paper-thin**, and grow on **conifer** wood (not hardwood)
- Oyster mushrooms are **thicker, fleshier**, and grow on **hardwood**
- Stick to hardwood-growing specimens and you're safe

If you find one

One of the most versatile wild mushrooms. Sauté, stir-fry, bread and fry, add to soups — they work with almost anything. Mild, slightly sweet flavor.

7. Porcini (King Bolete)

Boletus edulis

Status: EDIBLE — Intermediate ID

What it looks like

- **Cap:** Smooth, convex, brown to reddish-brown, 3–10 inches wide, slightly sticky when wet
- **Underside:** Spongy pore surface (NOT gills) — white when young, turning yellow-green with age
- **Stem:** Thick, bulbous, white to tan, with fine white netting (reticulation) on the upper portion
- **Flesh:** White, firm, does NOT change color when cut
- **Size:** 4–10 inches tall, sturdy and hefty

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Under conifers (spruce, pine, fir) and some hardwoods, in mountainous and northern forests
- **Season:** Summer through fall (July–October)
- **Grows:** Alone or scattered on forest floors

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Midwest | Rocky Mountains

Watch out for: Bitter Bolete (*Tylopilus felleus*)

- Looks nearly identical but tastes **intensely bitter** — one bite will tell you
- The netting on the stem is **darker/coarser** than porcini's fine white netting
- Pore surface turns **pinkish** with age (porcini stays yellow-green)
- Not toxic, just terrible tasting — will ruin a dish

If you find one

Porcini is one of the most sought-after culinary mushrooms in the world. Slice and sauté fresh, or dry slices for incredible concentrated flavor in risottos, pastas, and soups. The stem is edible too.

THE TOXIC 3

8. Death Cap

Amanita phalloides

Status: DEADLY TOXIC — Responsible for most mushroom-related deaths worldwide

What it looks like

- **Cap:** 2–6 inches wide, smooth, greenish-yellow to olive-green (sometimes pale white or brownish), slightly sticky when wet
- **Gills:** White, closely spaced, free (not attached to the stem)
- **Stem:** White, 3–6 inches tall, with a **skirt-like ring** (annulus) near the top
- **Base:** Bulbous, sitting inside a **cup-like sac (volva)** — often buried in soil. DIG IT UP to see this critical feature
- **Spore print:** White
- **Smell:** Young specimens smell pleasant, like honey or roses. This is deceptive.

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Under oaks and other hardwoods, in parks, yards, and forests. Originally from Europe, now widespread in North America
- **Season:** Fall and winter in mild climates; late summer through fall elsewhere
- **Grows:** Alone or in small groups on the ground

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast (expanding range)

Why it's so dangerous

- Contains **amatoxins** that destroy the liver and kidneys

- **Symptoms are delayed 6–24 hours** after eating — by the time you feel sick, severe organ damage may already be happening
- There is a deceptive "recovery" phase where you feel better before the final, potentially fatal stage
- **Half a cap can kill an adult**
- There is no reliable home antidote. If you suspect death cap ingestion, go to the ER immediately

Commonly confused with

- Paddy straw mushrooms (in Asian communities)
- Young puffballs (before the cap opens)
- Button mushrooms (to the untrained eye)

If you see one

Do not touch and eat. Handling alone is not dangerous — the toxins must be ingested. Take photos for your records and move on.

9. Destroying Angel

Amanita bisporigera / *A. virosa* / *A. ocreata*

Status: DEADLY TOXIC — As lethal as the Death Cap

What it looks like

- **Cap:** 2–5 inches wide, pure white, smooth, slightly convex to flat
- **Gills:** White, free from the stem
- **Stem:** White, tall and slender, with a **fragile skirt-like ring** that may disappear with age
- **Base:** Bulbous with a **sac-like volva** — often buried underground. **DIG IT UP**
- **Spore print:** White
- **Entire mushroom:** Completely white. Elegantly proportioned. Looks innocent.

Where & when

- **Habitat:** Near oaks, pines, and mixed forests. Also appears in lawns and gardens near trees
- **Season:** Summer through fall
- **Grows:** Alone or in small groups on the ground

Regions

Pacific Northwest | Northeast | Southeast | Midwest

Why it's so dangerous

- Contains the **same amatoxins** as the Death Cap
- Symptoms, timeline, and lethality are identical to the Death Cap
- Its **pure white, "clean" appearance** makes it look harmless — which is exactly why it's so deadly
- Nicknamed "Destroying Angel" because it looks beautiful and kills without mercy

Commonly confused with

- Button mushrooms (*Agaricus bisporus*)
- Young puffballs
- Meadow mushrooms
- Any small-to-medium white mushroom

The #1 rule with white mushrooms

If it's white, has gills, and grows from the ground — treat it as deadly until proven otherwise. This single rule could save your life.

10. Jack O'Lantern

Omphalotus olearius

Status: TOXIC — Will make you very sick, rarely fatal

What it looks like

- **Cap:** 2–8 inches wide, bright orange to orange-yellow, smooth, convex to funnel-shaped
- **Gills:** True, sharp, blade-like gills (not ridges) — orange, closely spaced, running slightly down the stem. **Gills glow faintly green in complete darkness** (bioluminescent)
- **Stem:** Orange, solid, central, tapers toward the base
- **Grows on:** Wood — stumps, buried roots, base of trees. **Always on or near wood**
- **Growth pattern:** Dense clusters, not solitary

Where & when

- **Habitat:** At the base of hardwood stumps or from buried roots (may look like it's growing from soil, but there's wood underneath)
- **Season:** Summer through fall (July–November)
- **Grows:** In clusters — multiple mushrooms from the same point

Regions

Northeast | Southeast | Midwest

Why it matters

The Jack O'Lantern is the mushroom most commonly confused with the Chanterelle (#1 in this guide). Every year, people get sick making this mistake. Here's how to tell them apart:

Feature	Chanterelle	Jack O'Lantern
Gills	False gills (forked ridges)	True, sharp gills
Growth	From soil, scattered	In clusters, on/near wood
Color inside	Pale/white flesh	Orange flesh throughout
Bioluminescence	No	Yes (gills glow in the dark)
Smell	Fruity, apricot-like	Unpleasant

If someone eats one

Symptoms (severe cramps, vomiting, diarrhea) usually begin within 1–2 hours. It's extremely unpleasant but rarely fatal in healthy adults. Seek medical attention.



Regional Quick-Reference

Find your hiking region and see which of the 10 mushrooms you're most likely to encounter.

Pacific Northwest

(Washington, Oregon, Northern California)

#	Mushroom	Status	Season
1	Chanterelle	Edible	Jun–Oct
2	Morel	Edible	Mar–May
3	Chicken of the Woods	Edible	May–Nov
5	Lion's Mane	Edible	Aug–Nov
6	Oyster Mushroom	Edible	Year-round
7	Porcini	Edible	Jul–Oct
8	Death Cap	DEADLY	Aug–Nov
9	Destroying Angel	DEADLY	Jun–Oct

PNW highlight: This region is chanterelle paradise. Pacific golden chanterelles can grow to dinner-plate size here. It's also where the Death Cap has been rapidly expanding — stay sharp.

Northeast & Appalachia

(New England, Mid-Atlantic, Appalachian states)

#	Mushroom	Status	Season
1	Chanterelle	Edible	Jul–Sep
2	Morel	Edible	Apr–May
3	Chicken of the Woods	Edible	Jun–Oct

#	Mushroom	Status	Season
4	Hen of the Woods	Edible	Sep–Nov
5	Lion's Mane	Edible	Aug–Nov
6	Oyster Mushroom	Edible	Spring & Fall
7	Porcini	Edible	Jul–Sep
8	Death Cap	DEADLY	Sep–Nov
9	Destroying Angel	DEADLY	Jun–Sep
10	Jack O'Lantern	TOXIC	Jul–Oct

Northeast highlight: The most diverse region in this guide — you could encounter all 10. Fall is the peak season, especially September–October.

Southeast

(Southeast US, Gulf states, Piedmont)

#	Mushroom	Status	Season
1	Chanterelle	Edible	Jun–Sep
2	Morel	Edible	Mar–Apr
3	Chicken of the Woods	Edible	May–Nov
4	Hen of the Woods	Edible	Oct–Nov
5	Lion's Mane	Edible	Sep–Nov
6	Oyster Mushroom	Edible	Year-round
8	Death Cap	DEADLY	Oct–Dec
9	Destroying Angel	DEADLY	Jun–Sep
10	Jack O'Lantern	TOXIC	Jul–Nov

Southeast highlight: Warm, humid conditions mean longer fruiting seasons. Chanterelles can be abundant after summer rains. Watch for Jack O'Lanterns — they love the heat.

Midwest

(Great Lakes, Plains states, Ohio Valley)

#	Mushroom	Status	Season
1	Chanterelle	Edible	Jul–Sep
2	Morel	Edible	Apr–May
3	Chicken of the Woods	Edible	Jun–Oct
4	Hen of the Woods	Edible	Sep–Nov
5	Lion's Mane	Edible	Aug–Oct
6	Oyster Mushroom	Edible	Spring & Fall
7	Porcini	Edible	Jul–Sep
9	Destroying Angel	DEADLY	Jun–Sep
10	Jack O'Lantern	TOXIC	Jul–Oct

Midwest highlight: Morel capital of North America. The spring morel season is practically a sport here — entire communities organize hunts. Check near dead elms and ash trees.

Southwest & Rocky Mountains

(Colorado, Utah, Arizona, New Mexico, mountainous West)

#	Mushroom	Status	Season
2	Morel	Edible	May–Jun
6	Oyster Mushroom	Edible	Spring & Fall
7	Porcini	Edible	Jul–Sep

Southwest highlight: Drier climate means fewer species, but the mountains compensate. Porcini thrive at elevation under spruce and fir. Post-fire morel hunts in burned mountain forests can be incredibly productive.

Emergency: What to Do If Someone Eats a Toxic Mushroom

Time matters. Act fast.

1. **Call Poison Control immediately:** 1-800-222-1222 (US) or your local emergency number
2. **Do NOT wait for symptoms.** With Death Cap and Destroying Angel, symptoms are delayed 6–24 hours. By the time you feel sick, organ damage is underway
3. **Save a sample** of the mushroom (or take clear photos) — this helps medical professionals identify what was eaten and choose the right treatment
4. **Do NOT try to induce vomiting** unless specifically told to by Poison Control or a doctor
5. **Go to the emergency room** — do not try to "wait it out" at home
6. **Note the time** the mushroom was eaten and when symptoms appeared

Symptoms by toxin type

Amatoxin poisoning (Death Cap, Destroying Angel): - 6–24 hours after eating: severe abdominal cramps, vomiting, watery diarrhea - 24–72 hours: deceptive improvement ("I feel better") - 3–5 days: liver and kidney failure. This is the critical danger zone

GI-irritant poisoning (Jack O'Lantern and most other toxic mushrooms): - 30 minutes to 2 hours: nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, cramps - Usually resolves within 24 hours with supportive care - Still see a doctor — don't self-diagnose the toxin type

What to Bring: Your Mushroom Hunting Gear List

You don't need much. Here's what fits in a daypack and makes all the difference:

The Essentials

- **A small knife or pocket blade** — to cleanly cut mushrooms at the base without disturbing the mycelium underground
- **Paper bags or wax paper bags** — never plastic. Plastic traps moisture and turns your finds into mush. Paper lets them breathe
- **A basket or mesh bag** — keeps specimens intact and lets spores drop as you walk (you're literally seeding the forest for next year)
- **Your phone (camera)** — for photos of every find: cap, underside, stem, base, and habitat. Non-negotiable

Nice to Have

- **A small hand lens / magnifying glass (10x)** — for examining gill structure, pore surfaces, and stem details up close
- **A field notebook or notes app** — jot down what tree species are nearby, the soil type, weather conditions. Your future self will thank you
- **Aluminum foil** — wrap individual specimens to keep them separated and protected
- **White + dark paper (index cards work)** — for spore prints right on the trail. Place the cap gill-side down, cover with a cup, and check after a few hours
- **Wet wipes** — always wash your hands after handling unknown mushrooms, especially before eating trail snacks
- **This guide (printed)** — print the mushroom pages for your region and the Quick Reference. Laminate if you want them to survive rain

What NOT to Bring

- **Plastic bags** — they destroy specimens. Leave them home

- **Overconfidence** — the most dangerous thing you can carry into the woods. When in doubt, leave it
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Your Trail ID Checklist

Use this checklist every time you find a mushroom on the trail:

- ☐ **Where is it growing?** Ground, wood, tree trunk, buried wood?
 - ☐ **What's nearby?** Oak, beech, conifer, mixed forest?
 - ☐ **How is it growing?** Alone, scattered, dense cluster?
 - ☐ **Cap:** Color, shape, size, texture (smooth, sticky, scaly)?
 - ☐ **Underside:** Gills, pores, ridges, or teeth/spines?
 - ☐ **Stem:** Color, thickness, ring/skirt, cup at base?
 - ☐ **Cut it open:** Hollow? Solid? Does the flesh change color?
 - ☐ **Smell:** Fruity? Earthy? Unpleasant? Like nothing?
 - ☐ **Photos taken?** Top, underside, stem, base, habitat — at least 5 shots
 - ☐ **Spore print started?** White paper + dark paper, gill-side down, 4–8 hours
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About This Guide

The Hiker's Mushroom Guide is a product of Paola Adventurer — helping everyday people step outside, try something new, and realize they're more capable than they think.

You don't need a biology degree to learn mushroom ID. You just need curiosity, patience, and a healthy respect for the ones that can hurt you.

Start with one mushroom. Learn it well. Then add another. Before you know it, you'll be the person on the trail saying, "Oh hey — that's a chanterelle."

Happy trails.

Paola Adventurer *Archery · Camping · Explore*

Disclaimer: This guide is for educational and informational purposes only. The author is not a mycologist or medical professional. Wild mushroom identification carries inherent risks. Never consume a wild mushroom unless you are 100% confident in your identification, ideally confirmed by an experienced forager. The author and Paola Adventurer assume no responsibility for illness or injury resulting from the use of this guide. Always follow local regulations regarding foraging and mushroom collection on public lands.